From the very beginning of your schooling career, you have been introduced to several different methods of writing essays. Although all structures have their advantages and disadvantages, it is essential that you have a fool-proof method of writing essays for your end of year examination.

Having a solid method of writing analytical essays and practicing these throughout the year will result in a strong foundation, enabling you to tackle any essay question with confidence. The key to success lies not only in understanding the content but also in being able to present your ideas in a clear, structured, and coherent manner. With a well-practised approach, you will be able to break down complex texts, analyse them effectively, and construct a well-supported argument that demonstrates both depth and clarity of thought.

In the following, we will explore a structured approach to writing an analytical text response. By familiarising yourself with this framework, you will be better equipped to organise your ideas, manage your time efficiently, and ultimately maximise your performance in the exam.

Reading the Question First

Before you write anything, underline the topic's key terms and its instruction word. The instruction word tells you what kind of answer is wanted. "To what extent" asks for a degree of agreement, so your contention has to say how far you agree. "Discuss" asks you to examine more than one side. "How does Weir…" asks for technique and effect. An introduction that answers a different instruction from the one in the question will lose marks even if the writing is good.

What a Strong Introduction Does

A strong introduction does three things in order, and it does them briefly. It names the text, the author and the form. It states your contention, which answers the question directly and takes a position. It then outlines three arguments, in the order your body paragraphs will follow. The reader should be able to predict the essay from the introduction alone.

Here is a short example built on a question about the short story "The Lottery", to show the three moves working together:

> *In Shirley Jackson's short story "The Lottery", the villagers take part in a ritual none of them questions. I agree that they conform out of fear of being excluded, although the story suggests this fear is learned rather than felt. Jackson builds this pressure through*

> *tradition, through the language of fairness and through the isolation of Tessie Hutchinson.*

The first sentence is the text, author and form. The second is the contention, and it qualifies the answer with "although" so that the position can be defended. The third sentence is the outline: three arguments, in the order they will appear.

Common Mistakes

- **Opening with a general statement** about life, society or human nature instead of the text. Assessors want to see the text in the first sentence.
- **A contention that avoids the question.** "Jackson writes about a village" is a fact, not an argument.
- **An outline that lists events**, such as "first the lottery starts, then Tessie protests". Name the arguments, not the plot.
- **An introduction that repeats the body.** The introduction should promise the argument; the body paragraphs deliver it.
- **Three arguments that do not connect.** If you cannot write a single sentence that links them, the contention is probably too broad.

Checking Your Introduction

Before you move on, check four things. Does the first sentence name the text, author and form? Does the contention answer the instruction word? Does the outline name three arguments in the same order your body paragraphs will use? Could you defend every sentence of it in the next three paragraphs? If the answer to any of these is no, fix it now, because the body paragraphs cannot repair an introduction that promises the wrong essay.

An essay is a structured piece of writing that presents an argument in response to a topic. In Section A, every essay has the same shape: an introduction, three body paragraphs, and a conclusion. Each part has a set job, and the introduction and conclusion follow the same structure.

Introduction

The introduction tells the marker which text you are writing about, what you think about the topic, and how your essay will prove it. Write it in three moves, in this order.

1 **Text, author and form**

Name the text, its author (or director) and its form: novel, film, play, short story collection.

2 **Contention**

Your answer to the topic, in one clear sentence.

3 **Three arguments**

Outline the argument of each body paragraph, in the order they will appear.

Topic: 'The desire for social acceptance shapes the behaviour of many of Jackson's characters.' Do you agree?

> Model introduction
>
> ❶ In her 1949 short story collection *The Lottery and Other Stories*, Shirley Jackson exposes the quiet pressures that sit beneath ordinary American life. ❷ Jackson suggests that the desire for social acceptance shapes much of her characters' behaviour, although it is often the fear of exclusion, rather than a wish to belong, that drives them. ❸ Her characters conform to avoid the judgement of their communities, construct false versions of themselves in order to appear successful, and, at their worst, take part in cruelty so that they are not the ones left outside.

Body Paragraphs

An essay normally has three body paragraphs, one for each argument named in your introduction and in the same order. Build each one with Th.E.S.A.M.L.

Th **Thematic-based topic sentence**

Your topic sentence needs to be based upon a theme in the text, not a character.

✗ *'Tessie Hutchinson is stoned to death by the villagers.'*
✓ *'Jackson suggests that blind loyalty to tradition allows ordinary people to commit*

extraordinary cruelty.'

E

Evidence

Quotes and scenes from the text that support the theme.

S

Symbols

Symbols that relate to this theme — including historical and social context, and setting.

A

Authorial intention

What was the author intending?

M

Metalanguage

Discuss the metalanguage the author uses around this theme.

L

Linking sentence

Link back to your contention.

Only the **Th** and **L** elements need to appear in this order — the middle elements can be woven through the paragraph.

Conclusion

The conclusion has the same structure as the introduction. Return to the text, author and form, restate your contention, and sum up your three arguments, this time as conclusions you have proven rather than ideas you are about to explore. Use fresh wording and do not add new evidence.

1

Text, author and form

Name the text, its author (or director) and its form: novel, film, play, short story collection.

2 **Contention**

Restate your contention, in fresh words.

3 **Three arguments**

Sum up what each body paragraph proved, in the same order.

Model conclusion

❶ Across *The Lottery and Other Stories*, Shirley Jackson presents a world in which belonging is never guaranteed. ❷ The need to be accepted is one of the most powerful forces in her characters' lives, and fear of exclusion, more than a wish to belong, is what drives them. ❸ They conform to escape judgement, invent more impressive versions of themselves, and join in cruelty rather than become its target, revealing how fragile, and how dangerous, the desire for acceptance can be.

Moving Up the Mark Bands

Use this as a checklist on your draft. Each band move is a few things you can actually change. The wording of the bands comes from the Section A descriptors on the Exam Assessment Criteria page.

Before you start, check every body paragraph has:

- a topic sentence that states a theme, not a character;
- at least one quotation from the text;
- one technique (narration, setting, sound, a repeated image) and what it does;
- a last sentence that links back to your contention.

From 6 to 7

1. **Use the text in every body paragraph.** Count the quotations in each paragraph. If one has none, find a line that shows the idea you are making.

2. **Name one technique in each paragraph and say what it does.** Replace “Jackson uses a calm voice” with the effect: “the calm voice makes the violence sound ordinary”.
3. **Keep the argument going to the end of the paragraph.** If the last sentence only retells the story, rewrite it to say what the story shows.

From 7 to 8

1. **Explain how the technique produces the idea.** Use this order: technique, then effect on the reader, then the idea about the topic.
2. **Link every paragraph back to the contention in its last sentence.** Your essay should read as one argument, not three separate points.
3. **Cut repetition.** Read the essay aloud. If two sentences say the same thing, keep the more precise one.

Worked example, using the Lottery low sample, body paragraph 2.

- **Before (6):** “Tessie is the only one who complains. She says ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right’. The other villagers tell her to be a good sport. This shows people are afraid of being different.”
- **After (7–8):** “Tessie is the only one who complains, and her ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right’ is answered not with an argument but with ‘Be a good sport, Tessie’. That reply turns a question of fairness into a question of manners, which is how the village keeps dissent quiet. The pressure is social, not violent, and that is why conformity lasts.”

From 8 to 9 or 10

1. **Show one complication.** Find a piece of evidence that works against your view. Answer it in one sentence, then say what your view still is or where it needs limiting.
2. **Use precise verbs for what the text does.** Replace “shows” and “reveals” with the action itself: “silences”, “exposes”, “normalises”. Check each verb against the text.
3. **Check every claim.** Each sentence should point to something a marker can find in the text. If a sentence is a general comment about life, cut it or tie it to the text.

Practice

Take the Picnic low sample and apply the 6-to-7 checklist to one paragraph. Then take the Picnic medium sample and apply the 8-to-9 checklist to the same paragraph. The difference between the two is the band move.
Where this comes from. The band wording is from the Section A descriptors on the Exam Assessment Criteria page. The steps are practical advice based on that wording. The VCAA 2024 and 2025 reports could not be checked when this was written, so nothing here is attributed to them.

Deconstructing the Prompt

When first planning your essay, you must directly respond to the prompt that is presented to you, and consider the key authorial messages that could help you respond with insight. This involves three important steps:

- Find the key concepts. This will most likely correlate with the key concepts you have studied throughout the unit, you should also make sure to identify synonyms of these concepts too!
- Find any instructional verbs. These are words that instruct you to answer the prompt in a certain manner, in English the main verbs to look out for is discuss, do you agree, to what extent or how.
- Identify any expectations/limitations. These ore words that limit what you con include in your essays and set on expectation on what you should be discussing.

Example prompt: *'In Jackson's stories, characters conform because they are afraid of being excluded.' Do you agree?*

This prompt has three key concepts: *conform*, *afraid* and *excluded*. The instructional phrase is "Do you agree?", which allows you to agree, disagree or argue a conditional position. The word *because* is the expectation to test: the topic claims fear is the *reason* characters conform, so a strong response asks whether fear is the only reason, or whether habit, tradition, ambition or cruelty also play a part. As *The Lottery and Other Stories* is a collection, you are expected to range across several stories, such as 'Flower Garden', 'The Renegade', 'Of Course' and 'The Lottery'. Consider the historical context of small-town and suburban America in the late 1940s, where respectability and belonging mattered and difference was viewed with suspicion.

Contention

Now that you understand what the prompt is asking, we can begin to think about our interpretation of Jackson's message. Let's consider the prompt again:

'In Jackson's stories, characters conform because they are afraid of being excluded.' Do you agree?

We can approach this in multiple ways. Here are three simplistic interpretations (agree, disagree, somewhere in between):

- Jackson suggests that her characters conform because they are afraid of being left out.
- Jackson implies that conformity in her stories comes from habit and tradition rather than fear.
- Jackson shows that some characters conform out of fear, while others resist.

However, these interpretations are quite general and lack specificity. They don't tell the reader exactly what you are arguing. Let's improve them with more precise language and deeper knowledge of the text:

- Jackson suggests that fear of exclusion drives much of her characters' conformity, as Mrs Winning's abandonment of Mrs MacLane in 'Flower Garden' shows, but reveals that this fear is most dangerous when it hardens into a community's cruelty towards outsiders.
- Jackson implies that conformity is often unthinking rather than fearful, as in 'The Lottery', where villagers preserve a ritual whose meaning they have long forgotten, suggesting that habit can be as powerful as fear.
- Jackson presents conformity as a choice made under pressure, contrasting characters who give in, such as Mrs Winning, with those who quietly resist, such as Mrs MacLane, and showing that resistance in her communities always carries a cost.

These improved interpretations use specific language, engage with the complexity of the characters' motivations, and demonstrate a sophisticated understanding of the collection's ideas.

Extending Sentences - Connectives

To create a 'sophisticated' idea you need to avoid single ideas, all of the contentions above are singular and lack connections to other ideas. We can connect them together using three simple connectives (and their advanced synonyms!)

Useful Conjunctions and Their Purposes

Conjunction	Purpose	Synonyms
Because	This conjunction explains why the information you have stated is true, demonstrating greater understanding of the author's purpose.	As, as a result of, considering, being, for, through, seeing as.
But	This conjunction adds contradictory information, allowing for greater debate.	However, nevertheless, yet, despite, even so, nonetheless, except.
So	This conjunction allows for inferencing the cause and effect of the statement, which demonstrates greater thinking and ideas about the text.	Therefore, consequently, accordingly, leading to.

From here, we can take these singular idea contentions and extend them with these connectives in order to make multi-idea contentions that can create sophisticated links between ideas:

Topic Sentences

Now we can create topic sentences that allow to explore complex ideas linked using BECAUSE, BUT & so.

Authorial Message/Intent - NOT PLOT OR CHAPTER!

The sentence should be focused on an authorial message, not just a concept or character make the author active -the most common start is the **author**+ verb:

E.g **Jackson** explores/communicates/illustrates etc.

Authorial Verbs

Analytical Verbs for Text Analysis

Conveys	Explores	Demonstrates	Emphasises
Communicates	Depicts	Illustrates	Challenges
Identifies	Frames	Reveals	Highlights
States	Implies	Suggests	Underlines

Prepositional Phrases

Another way to structure this sentence is to use a *prepositional phrase* at the beginning of the sentence that introduces ideas to vary your sentence structure:

Throughout the collection, Jackson explores..

Textual Analysis Phrases and Sentence Starters

Throughout	By (authorial verb)	In keeping with	With an eye to
Through	From the outset	In the absence of	Under the
By	Beyond the	Within the	To the extent
During	Concerning the	Without	

Specificity and Relevancy

Examiners punish vague or general statements, especially those that lack clear links to the topic or the author's message. For example:

By showing that characters want to fit in, Jackson shows that conformity matters in her stories.

This is not technically incorrect, but it is far too general and superficial. It doesn't demonstrate insightful analysis, nor does it show a clear understanding of Jackson's authorial intent. This kind of vague sentence would not receive full marks.

Here's an improved version:

By charting Mrs Winning's retreat from her friendship with Mrs MacLane in 'Flower Garden', Jackson portrays conformity not as a free choice, but as the price of belonging in a community that polices its boundaries.

This is better. It is clear, specific, well structured, and shows awareness of the idea (conformity and exclusion), character motivation and authorial message. It also links directly to the contention: that fear of exclusion drives the characters' conformity.

The issue you will face is that there is only so much you can discuss in your paragraph from here, as you have only examined one idea: conformity is the price of belonging. To fix this, let's go back to an old friend:

Because, But, So - Make a Complex Sentence!

Too often, students fail to complete long paragraphs because they are stuck repeating themselves or have run out of things to say about the topic they introduced. Therefore, if we

have two ideas in our topic sentence, we can 'hinge' these sentences together, which demonstrates complex understanding, writing and structure. All of these are key parts of the rubric you are judged on! Here's an example:

> *By charting Mrs Winning's retreat from her friendship with Mrs MacLane, Jackson conveys how the fear of exclusion pushes characters to abandon their own judgement, ultimately suggesting that a community which rewards conformity turns its members into the enforcers of its prejudice.*

Now, you have two linked ideas:

- The fear of exclusion pushes characters to abandon their own judgement.
- In doing so, they become the people who enforce the community's prejudice.

This provides a clear structure for an entire paragraph and sets you up to use a hinge sentence later to develop further layers, such as how this pattern reaches its most extreme form in 'The Lottery'.

By planning your paragraph in this way, you'll ensure:

- Specific and sophisticated analysis
- Strong authorial intent
- Complex understanding of the characters' motivations and Jackson's critique of conformity in post-war American communities

Every Section A topic is new, and every topic is more than a single concept. The exam will never ask "tell me everything the author says about punishment". It will modify the concept, by asking about its causes, its consequences, its impact, or its relationship with another idea. Reading time is where you take the topic apart before you commit to a contention.

Questions to Ask of Every Topic

- **Absolutes.** Look for words such as *all*, *no one*, *only*, *always*. Is the claim true for everyone in the text? If not, who is the exception, and why (class, gender, race, belief, family)?
- **Modifiers.** Adverbs and adjectives change the question. "Punished" and "justly punished" are different essays. "Moments" and "lasting, ordinary moments" are different essays. Define each

modifier before you plan.

- **Connotation.** “Fear that is justified” is not “irrational fear”. “Infatuation with youth” implies shallowness and impermanence that “love of youth” does not.
- **Comparison.** *Most*, *more than*, *as guilty as*, *strongest*: these words require you to weigh one thing against another, not discuss one thing alone.
- **Connections.** “Change is inevitable” implies nothing can stay the same. “Interplay” means two ideas act on each other, not a one-way cause.
- **The verb.** *Celebrates*, *condemns*, *warns*, *mocks* each tell you the author’s attitude. Do not flatten them into “presents”.

Two Kinds of Quotation Topic

Quotation topics do not all work the same way, so read them closely.

- **The quote as a key moment.** The quote is attached to a question (“How is the idea of truth explored?”). The panel has chosen a passage that matters to the question. Decide where it fits in your sequence of ideas and discuss it there.
- **The quote as the proposition.** The quote is the claim you are asked to assess (“To what extent does the author demonstrate this to be true?”). Here the quote *is* the topic. Treating it as one piece of evidence would mean missing the question entirely.

Ordering Is Not Connecting

“Firstly”, “secondly”, “initially”, “subsequently” put paragraphs in order. They do not explain how one idea relates to the next. A connection says *why* paragraph two follows paragraph one: it builds on it, qualifies it, complicates it, or shows its consequence. Before you write, check two things in your plan: that every topic sentence answers the topic, and that you can state the link between each pair of paragraphs in one phrase.

Concepts Worth Rehearsing

Recent Section A topics have centred on concepts such as hardship, home, control, social convention, threat, knowledge, punishment, truth, choice and privilege. The panel can and does introduce new ones. A useful revision routine: take each concept, ask what your text says about it, then ask what it says about the concept’s causes, its consequences, and its relationship to a second concept. You build knowledge and practise the skill at the same time.

The study design asks you to analyse the *dynamics* of a text. These are lenses for knowing your text so well that any topic can be answered. They do not sit in separate boxes: a character's motivation usually connects to a tension, a setting or a point of view. Make one page of notes for each lens, with evidence.

1. Character Motivations

Ask why each character does what they do. Is the drive emotional (fear, anger, joy), moral (duty, loyalty, compassion), self-image (wanting to seem good or honourable), or cultural, religious and social (beliefs strong enough to compel action)? Note where motivation *changes*: a character driven by money early may be driven by conscience later.

One quotation can support several readings. When Old Man Warner insists, "There's always been a lottery", his loyalty could be read as reverence for tradition, as fear of change (he warns that without it "they'll be wanting to go back to living in caves"), as pride in his own status ("Seventy-seventh year I been in the lottery"), or as superstition about the harvest ("Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon"). Choose the reading the topic needs, and use the words of the quote as your evidence for it.

For *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, try the same exercise with Mrs Appleyard's decision to send Sara back to the orphanage, Michael's search on the Rock, or Irma's return.

2. Tensions in Relationships

Tension is the friction between two characters: betrayal, misunderstanding, conflicting desires, secrecy, trauma, gender expectations, social order. Look at the language a character uses about the other. Line up the key relationships and note what rubs them against each other and whether it is resolved.

3. The Function of Settings

Naming the setting in your introduction earns little. Explaining what a setting *does* earns a great deal. Ask: of all places, why this one? Does it mirror a character's mood, or contrast with it to raise tension? Does it confine characters or free them? Does it give someone authority or take it away? Useful phrasing: "the setting functions as a physical manifestation of", "the confined setting reinforces", "the setting intensifies the conflict between".

For *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the Rock functions as an ancient, indifferent force that dwarfs the girls, while Appleyard College functions as a fortress of imported order. For *The Lottery and*

Other Stories, the sunny village square makes the ritual feel routine, and in 'Flower Garden' the cottage and its garden stand for the life Mrs Winning gave up.

4. The Complexities of the Plot

Map the plot on one large page. Is it linear or non-linear? Are there flashbacks, flash-forwards, frame narratives, dream sequences, circular endings? Then ask why the author chose this sequence. A structural choice (the title card and slow-motion picnic that frame *Picnic at Hanging Rock*; the calm, ordinary build-up of 'The Lottery' before the stoning) is evidence you can use.

5. The Role of Point of View

Whose voice do we hear? Whose perspective are we denied? Is the narrator reliable, and how do we know? Do characters see the same person differently? Does the audience know things characters do not (dramatic irony)? Useful phrasing: "by aligning the audience with", "the limited perspective heightens", "from Mrs Walpole's point of view, however".

Beyond the Dynamics

The study design also names: ideas, concerns and conflicts (not "themes": turn a theme into the concerns and conflicts it raises); structures and language features (symbolism, dramatic irony, parallel plots, repetition, stage directions, film techniques), always explained for *how* and *why*; and the historical, social and cultural values of the world of the text, used as evidence in body paragraphs rather than only as a line in the introduction.

Connect the Lenses

Once each lens has its own page, link them. A mind map or colour coding works well: mark the quotes that serve more than one lens (a line that reveals a motivation *and* uses a key language feature), because those are the most flexible pieces of evidence on exam day. Some lenses will matter more for your text than others; that is expected.

Five Ways to Substantiate

No assessor counts types of evidence. But a response that draws on only quotations shows a narrower range than one that also uses characters, structure, plot, setting, language features and context. Quality beats quantity: each piece of evidence must be explained, not just included.

Topics

There are three types of questions you may receive on a SAC or exam. These are the ‘Discuss’, ‘To what extent’ and ‘Do you agree?’ statements. These are all tackled in a slightly varying manner.

- Discuss : This is probably the most common type of prompt that you will encounter. When dealing with such prompts, it is important that you discuss as many aspects of it as possible. One way to improve your discussion here is to include a paragraph that rebuts the prompt, like what you do in your persuasive essays. However, since it is a discuss prompt, you do not need to make the two sides of your argument extremely distinct.

- To what extent: These topics require you to make a decision. Never say ‘it is to some extent’ in your contention. You really need to assign a portion of something. The best way to do this is to start with subordinating conjunctions like ‘whilst” or ‘although”. To What Extent questions rarely want you to agree or disagree - they want you to explore a shade of grey.

- How: The ‘How’ topics usually focus on the construction of a text - your evidence should contain metalanguage like ‘characterisation’ for instance.

Introduction

The introduction is the first piece of your writing that will be examined. For this reason, it should be clear, direct and show your understanding of the topic. The introduction is there to show your examiner how you wish to respond to the set topic.

If your topic contains a quote, ensure that you mention it somewhere in your introduction to show you are addressing the topic.

Structure

An introduction must include the following:

A General Line of introduction

Too often our introductions lack any insight and mainly begin with author+text+background information which has nothing to do with the actual topic. We should attempt to be relevant with our opening statement and discuss why this concept is important.

Phrases to Introduce	Analytical Verbs	Noun Phrases and Structures
Throughout literature...	Conveys	the challenges of...
Authors are often preoccupied with...	Explores	the pressures and difficulties of...
Much of human thought has focused on...	Emphasises	the dangerous nature of...
In these ... worlds created by authors...	Directs	the devastating impact of...
Most stories are characterised...	Engages	the importance of...
The importance of... is often highlighted...	Establishes	the consequences of...
	Depicts	the conflict between...
	Grapples	the ... it requires...
	Highlights	the way ... can...
	Illustrates	the ways in which ... can...
	Challenges	the way ... shapes and influences...
	Composes	how ... leads to...
		how ... is able to...
		how ... creates...
		how ... causes...
		how ... challenges us to...
		how ... forces us to...
		how ... compels us...
		how not only ... but also...
		what it means to be...
		what it means for...
		what happens when...
		how a world where...

Phrases to Introduce	Analytical Verbs	Noun Phrases and Structures
		how societies in which...
		how times of...
		how situations in which...

Introduce the Text, Author and Contention

Now we introduce the text and author and the audience. Then state how it relates to the topic specifically. These need to be connected fluently, when writing we should be relying on connectives to make sure there is a logical flow in our expression.

Depending on the prompt itself, it might be a wise idea to link either/both of characters and setting to the topic of the essay prompt. We can do this as such:

Linking a Character to a Topic:

Sentence Starters: Character Discovery and Purpose

Introductory Phrase	Verb of Discovery	Linking Phrase
As the main character...	Discover/s	in order to...
As the leading character...	Find/s	so that...
As the hero/ine...	Learn/s	by...
As the main focus...	Understand/s	to become...
As the protagonist...	Accepts/s	to work towards...
	Admit/s	since...
	Challenges/s	it is not as important as...
	Confront/s	isn't as necessary as...
	Seeks/s	can never be a substitute for...
	Realise/s	

N.B. the title of a text is always underlined when handwritten (and italicised when typed), i.e. Picnic at Hanging Rock or The Lottery and Other Stories. The title of an individual story goes in single quotation marks, e.g. 'The Lottery'.

Contention

A contention is the author's point of view on the topic. Since you are the author in this scenario, you need to write what your position on the topic. A contention should be short, to the point, and engage with the topic. On this falls the crux of your essay.

Do not be afraid to agree/disagree with a topic. You are allowed to have a conditional contention.

Body Paragraphs

The body paragraphs form majority of your essay. The body paragraphs are the main reasons that the contention your provided is true. Your body paragraphs need to be able to demonstrate your understanding of the text and the fluency of your language. You should ensure that every sentence (and thus every word) brings something towards your argument.

Structure

Below is the structure for a body paragraph using 'Th.E. S.A.M.L.' Method. This method of writing body paragraphs was developed in order to maximise possible marks. Only the 'TH' and 'L' elements of this structure need to be in the order given.

Th

Thematic-based topic sentence

Your topic sentence needs to be based upon a theme in the text, not a character.

✗ *'Tessie Hutchinson is stoned to death by the villagers.'*
✓ *'Jackson suggests that blind loyalty to tradition allows ordinary people to commit extraordinary cruelty.'*

E

Evidence

Quotes and scenes from the text that support the theme.

S

Symbols

Symbols that relate to this theme — including historical and social context, and setting.

A **Authorial intention**

What was the author intending?

M **Metalanguage**

Discuss the metalanguage the author uses around this theme.

L **Linking sentence**

Link back to your contention.

Only the **Th** and **L** elements need to appear in this order — the middle elements can be woven through the paragraph.

Basic Example 'Th.E S.A.M'

> *Jackson suggests that blind loyalty to tradition allows ordinary people to commit extraordinary cruelty. In 'The Lottery', Old Man Warner insists that "There's always been a lottery", dismissing the villages that have given it up as a "Pack of crazy fools". The battered black box, which the villagers refuse to replace even as it grows "shabbier each year", symbolises a ritual whose meaning has decayed while its authority remains. Writing in the years after the Second World War, Jackson warns that cruelty is most dangerous when it is habitual and shared. Her flat, matter-of-fact narration of the stoning, in which "someone gave little Davy Hutchinson a few pebbles", makes the violence more disturbing by presenting it as ordinary. In this way, Jackson shows that loyalty to tradition can blind a community to its own cruelty.*

Writing About Ideas: Adding Adjectives to Nouns

One of the easiest ways of improving your writing is to add adjectives to nouns, this helps us to create an 'idea phrase'. Here is a list of commonly used nouns in analytic writing, a good way is to use these as springboards to finding even more complex and advanced nouns.

Idea Nouns for Analytical Writing

Column 1	Column 2	Column 3	Column 4	Column 5
Growing up	Survival	Justice	Friendship	Loss

Column 1	Column 2	Column 3	Column 4	Column 5
Independence	Conflict	Humanity	Family	Guilt
Coming of age	Courage	Prejudice	Relationship	Redemption
Maturity	Strength	Oppression	Belonging	Hope
Identity	Bravery	Injustice	Loneliness	Grief
Discovery	Persistence	Power	Loyalty	Sorrow
Revelation	Fortitude	Greed	Betrayal	Memory
Concealment	Heroism	Selfishness	Love	Future
Blossom	Resilience	Competence	Hatred	Past
Deteriorate	Cowardice	Potential	Envy	Melancholy

We then can pair these ideas with adjectives of degree - these tell us how big, small, frequent, fast or slow something is, here is a list to help build your writing vocabulary:

small

Adjectives of Degree for Analytical Writing

Category	BIG (Intensifying)	SMALL (Minimising)
SIZE	Deep, Immense, Extensive, Overwhelming	Empty, Insignificant, Little, Tiny
STRENGTH	Extreme, Powerful, Fierce, Determined	Weak, Uncertain, Fragile, Feeble
SPEED	Rapid, Swift, Impulsive, Sudden	Slow, Reluctant, Hesitant, Glacial
CONSISTENCY	Frequent, Constant, Incessant, Unchanging	Unsteady, Unreliable, Erratic, Unstable

Hinge Sentences

In your topic sentence, you can introduce two related ideas. This creates room for a more complex, insightful paragraph. But remember: when you shift focus from the first idea to the second, you must signal this change to the reader clearly. This is where the hinge sentence comes in.

A hinge sentence acts like a bridge: it acknowledges what you've already explored, then transitions to the second idea you introduced in your topic sentence. Here's how that works:

> *By charting Mrs Winning's retreat from her friendship with Mrs MacLane, Jackson conveys how the fear of exclusion pushes characters to abandon their own judgement, ultimately suggesting that a community which rewards conformity turns its members into the enforcers of its prejudice.*

Evidence + Analysis of First Idea

In 'Flower Garden', Mrs Winning's friendship with Mrs MacLane survives only until the town begins to disapprove of Mrs MacLane hiring Mr Jones. When her mother-in-law urges her to "talk to her about that colored man working there", Mrs Winning's private thoughts reveal what really moves her: "pretty soon they'll stop coming to me first, they'll tell someone else to speak to me." Jackson shows that her concern is not for her friend, or even for what is right, but for her own place in the community.

Hinge Sentence (transitioning to Second idea)

However, Jackson does not leave Mrs Winning as a mere victim of social pressure; she shows her becoming its agent.

Analysis of Second Idea

When Mrs MacLane asks whether the town's coldness is "because of Mr. Jones working here", Mrs Winning denies it, then privately thinks, "The nerve of her, trying to blame the colored folks." Having absorbed the town's prejudice, she now voices it as her own. Her final gesture, as she "swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house", is deeply ironic: the "dignity" she preserves is the dignity of belonging, bought at the cost of her friend.

By using a hinge sentence, you show your reader that you're not just stacking ideas but developing an argument, deepening your interpretation, and showing the author's nuanced message.

Concluding Dependant Phrases Paired with Analytic Verbs

Concluding Dependant Phrase	Analytic Verb
Even if Jackson recognises...	questions...

Concluding Dependant Phrase	Analytic Verb
Whilst Weir endorses...	illustrates...
Whether or not Jackson implies...	reveals...
In order to explore ... Weir ...	demonstrates...

Conclusion

If you think of a conclusion as less of summarising everything, and more of combining all of these conflicting ideas and messages into one overall conclusive point. We can do this by using the following structure.

Structure

The structure for a conclusion can follow the same structure as an introduction. However, instead of introducing the text, you are concluding your discussion.

Here is an alternative method:

Topic:

> *'In Jackson's stories, characters conform because they are afraid of being excluded.' Do you agree?*

Conclusion Structure for Analytical Essay Writing

Purpose in Conclusion	Example Sentence
Overview of how the whole text demonstrates the key concepts in the essay topic	Fundamentally, *The Lottery and Other Stories* explores the pressure to belong, and how readily ordinary people give up their own judgement to avoid standing apart.
Summary of the complications of this topic	Throughout the collection, Jackson complicates the idea that fear alone drives conformity, showing that habit, tradition and the pleasure of belonging can be just as powerful, as the villagers of 'The Lottery' reveal.
Focus on the key authorial message in conclusive language	Therefore, Jackson warns that a community which punishes difference turns its members into the enforcers of its prejudice, as Mrs Winning becomes in 'Flower Garden'.

The Initial Concluding Sentence

Here is a list of concluding and verb phrases you can use at the beginning of your conclusion.

Concluding Sentence Starters and Verb Phrases

Concluding Phrase	Verb Phrase
Essentially,	explores
Fundamentally,	is a text about...
At its core,	critiques
At its heart,	is a novel that...
Ultimately,	examines
In the end,	is a science fiction tale
In the final analysis,	exposes
Everything considered,	that...

Sentence Starters

To introduce		
This essay discusses ...	... is explored ...	... is defined ...
The definition of ... will be given	... is briefly outlined ...	... is explored ...
The issue focused on ...	... is demonstrated ...	... is included ...
In this essay ...	... is explained ...	... are identified ...
The key aspect discussed ...	... are presented ...	... is justified ...
Views on ... range from	... is evaluated ...	... is examined ...
The central theme ...	... is described ...	... is analysed ...
Emphasised are ...	... is explained and illustrated with examples ...	

To conclude		
In summary, ...	To review, ...	In conclusion, ...

To conclude		
In brief, ...	To summarise, ...	To sum up, ...
To conclude, ...	Thus, ...	Hence, ...
It has been shown that ...	In short, ...	

To compare and contrast		
Similarly, ...	In the same way ...	Likewise, ...
In comparison ...	Complementary to this ...	Then again, ...
However, ...	This is in contrast to ...	In contrast, ...
And yet ...	Nevertheless, ...	Conversely, ...
On the contrary, ...	On the other hand, ...	Notwithstanding ...
Whereas ...	In contrast to ...	That aside, . . .
While this is the case ...	. . . disputes ...	Despite this, . . .

To add ideas		
Also, ...	Equally important . . .	Subsequently, ...
Futhermore, ...	Moreover, ...	As well as . . .

Next ...	Another essential point ...	Additionally, . . .
More importantly, ...	In the same way ...	Another . . .
Then, ...	In addition, ...	Besides . . .
Then again, ...	Firstly, ... secondly, ... thirdly, ... finally, ...	To elaborate, . . .

To present uncommon or rare ideas		
Seldom . . .	Few . . .	Not many . . .
A few . . .	. . . is uncommon	. . . is scarce . . .

Rarely . . .	. . . is rare . . .	. . . is unusual . . .

To present common or widespread ideas		
Numerous . . .	Many . . .	More than . . .
Several . . .	Almost all . . .	The majority . . .
Most . . .	Commonly . . .	Significant . . .
. . . is prevalent . . .	. . . is usual . . .	Usually . . .

To present inconclusive ideas		
Perhaps . . .	. . . may be . . .	. . . might be . . .
There is limited evidence for . . .	. . . is debated . . .	. . . is possibly . . .
. . . could . . .	. . . may include . . .	

To give examples		
For example, . . .	. . . as can be seen in . . .	. . . supports . . .
An illustration of . . .	. . . as demonstrated by . . .	. . . is observed . . .
Specifically, . . .	. . . is shown . . .	. . . exemplifies . . .
Such as . . .	As an example . . .	To illustrate, . . .
For instance, ...		

Therefore . . .	As a result . . .	For that reason . . .
Hence, . . .	Otherwise, . . .	Consequently, . . .
The evidence suggests/shows . . .	It can be seen that . . .	With regard to . . .
After examining . . .	These factors contribute to . . .	It is apparent that . . .
Considering ... it can be concluded that ...	Subsequently, . . .	The effect is . . .
The outcome is . . .	The result . . .	The correlation . . .

The relationship . . .	The link . . .	the convergence . . .
The connection . . .	. . . interacts with . . .	Both . . .
. . . affects . . .	Thus it is . . .	. . . causes . . .
. . . influences . . .	. . . predicts . . .	. . . leads to . . .
. . . informs . . .	. . . presupposes	. . . emphasises
. . . demonstrates . . .	. . . impacts on . . .	. . . supports . . .

To present prior or background ideas		
In the past, . . .	Historically, . . .	Traditionally, . . .
Customarily, . . .	Beforehand, . . .	Originally, . . .
Prior to this, . . .	Earlier, . . .	Formerly, . . .
Previously, . . .	Over time, . . .	At the time of . . .
Conventionally, . . .	Foundational to this is . . .	In earlier . . .
Initially, . . .	At first, . . .	Recently . . .
Until now, . . .	The traditional interpretation . . .	

To present others' ideas		
According to . . .	Based on the findings of ... it can be argued . . .	... proposed that ...
As explained by ...	... states that ...	... claims that ...
However, ... stated that ...	... suggested ...	... concluded that ...
Similarly, ... stated that ...	... for example, ...	... agreed that ...
Based on the ideas of ...	... defined ... as ...	... relates ...
As identified by ...	... disputed that ...	... contrasts ...
With regard to ... argued that ...	... concluded that ...	... confirmed that ...
. . . argues ...	... highlights ...	... demonstrates ...

… found that …	… identifies …	. . . wrote that …

… demonstrated …	… also …	… reported …
… pointed out that …	… maintained that …	… hypothesised that …
… expressed the opinion that …	. . . also mentioned …	. . . asserts that …
… identified …	… goes on to state/suggest/say	… emphasises
… challenges the idea …	… showed that …	… explored the idea …

Take a Break Before Proofreading

After finishing your essay, your mind is still fresh with ideas, but it may be too familiar with the text to catch all mistakes. Step away from the essay for at least 10–15 minutes. This will help you approach it with fresh eyes and a clearer mindset when you return to review it.

Read Aloud

Reading aloud forces you to slow down and focus on each word. It also helps you hear awkward phrasing or sentences that don't flow well. Read your essay aloud, paying attention to how each sentence sounds. If something feels off or too long-winded, make adjustments.

Check for Structure and Coherence

A strong essay is logically structured with clear arguments and smooth transitions. Ensure each paragraph has a clear topic sentence. Verify your argument flows logically from one point to the next. Ensure your introduction sets up your essay well and your conclusion summarises without introducing new ideas.

Look for Clarity and Precision

Vague or unclear language can confuse your reader, even if the argument itself is solid. Check if any sentences can be more specific or concise. Remove unnecessary filler words like 'really,' 'just,' or 'quite.' Replace vague words like 'things' or 'stuff' with more precise terms.

Verify Your Thesis and Topic Sentences

Your thesis statement should be the central focus of your essay, and topic sentences should align with it. Double-check that:

- Your thesis is clear and present in the introduction.
- Each body paragraph clearly supports your thesis with an argument or evidence.
- Topic sentences match the content of their respective paragraphs.

Proofread for Grammar and Syntax

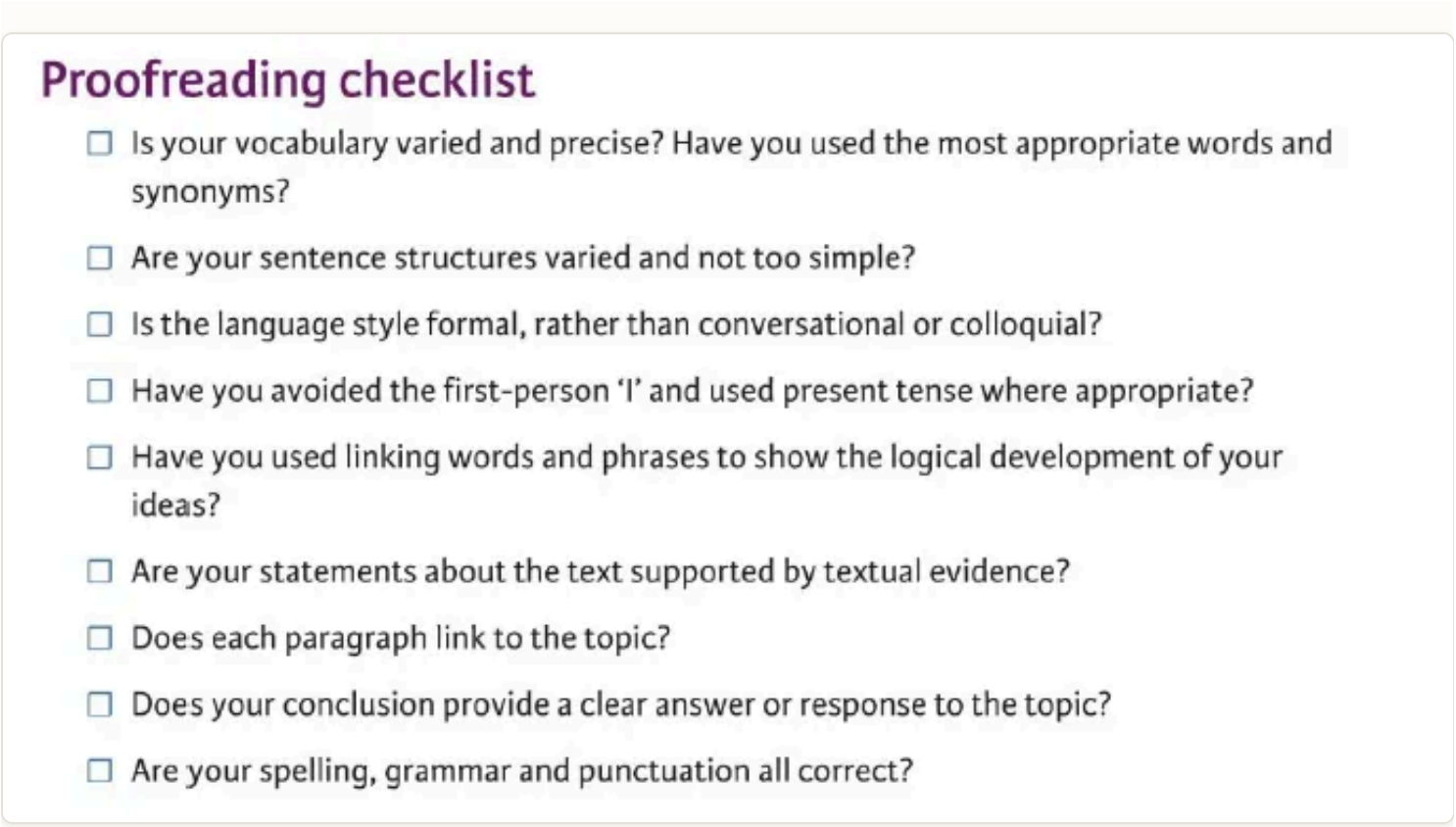
Grammar mistakes, awkward phrasing, or incorrect sentence structure can weaken the professionalism of your essay. Read through your essay for common mistakes (e.g., subject-verb agreement, incorrect punctuation, run-on sentences). Use tools like Grammarly or even Microsoft Word's spelling/grammar checker for a quick second look.

Check for Word Choice and Tone

The right word choice ensures your ideas are clear and impactful. Avoid overly complex words unless they are necessary for the context. Ensure you maintain an academic tone throughout the essay. Replace informal language (e.g., 'kids' or 'stuff') with more formal, specific terms.

Look for Repetition

Repeating the same word or idea can weaken your essay's overall impact. Identify words or phrases that appear too often. Use synonyms or restructure sentences to avoid redundancy. Consider varying sentence structures to keep the reader engaged.



Insight's Proofreading Checklist

Check Punctuation and Spacing

Simple punctuation errors or inconsistent spacing can distract the reader. Verify commas, full stops, and apostrophes are used correctly. Ensure there is proper spacing after full stops and between paragraphs.

Ask Someone Else to Read It

Fresh eyes can often spot mistakes you may have missed. Ask a peer, teacher, or family member to read your essay. Be open to their feedback and use it to improve your writing.

Ensure It Meets the Task Requirements

Your essay should always answer the question and meet the criteria specified in the prompt. Revisit the question to ensure your essay directly addresses it. Check that all key parts of the task are covered and that your argument is relevant.